



GAMIFICATION OF THE WORKPLACE

Who said work and pleasure shouldn't mix?

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Gamification isn't just a buzzword anymore. In fact, it's been more than just that since quite a while. A survey by tech research firm Gartner estimated that by 2014, about 70 percent of big corporations will incorporate gamification in some segment of their entire machinery. Many of these may be pilot programmes given that the concept has only recently gathered momentum. However, industry experts in an IEEE article (Find it here: <http://dgit.in/IEEEGoW>) believe that some form of gaming will be incorporated into 85 percent of the daily tasks in the workplace. Why don't we take a look at the reasons for so much traction of this concept.

Just to be clear...

We aren't talking about companies buying new rooms full of consoles where employees can go and dish out sweet justice onto their superiors in a bout of *Call of Duty*. That's not to say that a match of CoD won't help team bonding. Gamification is a concept that deals with many things such as incorporating company principles into a video game, using the video game's backend to actually contribute to a work process, training employees through a video game, boosting employees' physical fitness, incentivising work milestones, etc. If airplane pilots and soldiers can be trained for battle through simulators and games, then certainly a blue collar worker can be put through a similar initiative catering to the urban workplace.



A typical raid party in WoW grinding through a dungeon

Company picnic raid!

If you're still scratching your head wondering what we're talking about, then here's an example to help it make sense. There's this term called 'raids' in *World of Warcraft* (WoW), a massively multiplayer online role playing game (MMORPG) which involves working as a team. There are instances in WoW when it's extremely difficult for any single player to complete. This is because there are diverse player character classifications which are unique in nature and suited to perform only certain functions. A 'Warrior' is capable of taking a lot of damage while dishing out a lot less in return. A 'Mage' is capable of dishing out an insane amount of damage over a huge area but is as fragile as a toothpick. Then there are support classes ('Bards'/'Acolytes'), which don't partake in either the offence or defense. Instead, they help other classes improve their abilities. So no one character or even a group that consists of just one character class can handle a raid instance. Hence, a 'raid' group consisting of up to 40 players of all

character classes is formed which goes about trying to complete this instance. This group relies on the strengths of each individual at some point in the game to take the whole team forward.

Didn't this sound similar? Imagine programmers as warriors, sales and marketing as mages and managers as acolytes; and instead of a raid instance, consider the scenario to be a huge company contract. This is where the picture comes together and you realise how similar it is to a real-world scenario. Now, let's say your warrior just died (your programmer took a sick leave), your project should come to a halt and the same happens in these video games. There are redundancies and you learn when and where to use them.

While *World of Warcraft* is just one such game, there are many that happen to teach or train employees. John Seely Brown, independent co-chair of the Deloitte Center for Edge Innovation and Senior fellow, Annenberg Center for Communication at USC once said, "I would rather hire a high-level *World of Warcraft*